

Stoicism

Stoicism is a school of Hellenistic philosophy founded in Athens by Zeno of Citium around 300 BCE. Zeno taught at the Stoa Poikile (Painted Porch), from which the school takes its name.

Stoicism teaches that virtue (arete) is the only good and that external things — health, wealth, pleasure — are "preferred indifferents". The goal is to live in agreement with nature (logos), the rational principle that orders the universe.

Three Roman Stoics are particularly influential: - Epictetus (c. 50-135 CE), a former slave who taught in Nicopolis. His "Enchiridion" was compiled by his student Arrian. - Seneca (c. 4 BCE - 65 CE), a Roman statesman and tutor to Emperor Nero, who ordered him to commit suicide. - Marcus Aurelius (121-180 CE), Roman Emperor from 161 to 180. His private journal "Meditations" was written in Greek at military campaigns on the Danube.

Modern cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT), developed by Aaron Beck and Albert Ellis in the 1960s, draws heavily on Stoic techniques, particularly the idea that emotional disturbance comes from judgments about events, not the events themselves.